

3,000 YEARS OF WOMENSWEAR

From ancient civilizations to the present day, women's dress has been shaped not only by personal taste but by economic, political, and technological developments. As the centuries passed, new trade routes introduced exotic fabrics and adornments from distant lands, while the rise and fall of monarchies overturned dress styles and inspired new ones. Major agents of change included advances in technology, from loom to sewing machine, and from natural cloth to manmade fabrics such as Lycra. Against this backdrop sits self-expression: in the 1920s boyish shapes and shorter skirts celebrated new-found personal freedom; in the 1980s padded shoulders and tailored suits symbolized female power in a male-dominated workplace. Today the global fashion industry promotes a rapid turnover of styles that cross all national boundaries.



Ancient Greek chiton (reconstructed)
fastened at the shoulders



Mid-14th Century Surcoat
(reconstructed) worn over *cote-hardie*



1830s Cotton day dress with full gigot sleeves and a flounced hem



1850-54 Printed day dress with a bell-shaped skirt and pagoda sleeves



c.1888 Bustle dress with tailored jacket and waistcoat



1902 S-bend dress with pigeon-pouter chest and hips pushed back



1910-12 Lace bodice and skirt with sash to emphasize the narrow waist



1940s Utility dress cut to waste as little fabric as possible



1940s Checked dress showing width at the shoulders, worn with headscarf



1950s Day dress and matching bolero jacket, with full skirt over net petticoats



1950s Printed dress with fitted waist and pencil skirt, in a vibrant floral fabric



1960s Mini dress hemmed well above the knee, worn with white go-go boots